

The PVR application bundled with the PixelView cards hogged system resources so much that they brought our test machine to a virtual standstill for a few minutes. The Pinnacle PVR application interface needs a face-lift, while the application provided by Mercury can be best described as vanilla.

In the channel detection test, all cards fared well except for the Pinnacle PCTV Rave, which detected a miserably low 27 channels, and the PixelView PlayTV Pro2, which detected just 54 out of the total 87 available channels.

The problem probably lies in the bundled PVR application, because when we tried to use a third party PVR application, we could detect a lot more channels with both cards.

After the channel detection part of the test was over, we observed the visual quality of the channels, and found that the Compro VideoMate PVR/FM had the best image quality, followed by its more expensive siblings—the Compro VideoMate Gold II and Gold Plus II.

A point to be noted here is that the TV tuner cards with the Philips SAA713xHL chip

offered a much better image quality than the ones featuring Conexant chips.

In the capture test, which determines the number of frames dropped. Here, the PixelView PlayTV Pro2 scored the lowest by dropping seven frames—the maximum number of frames dropped.

The Mercury TV tuner card dropped six frames, and came second last, but the Compro TV tuners that performed flawlessly, and never dropped a single frame.

External TV Tuners

A PCI TV tuner card has inherent downsides. The tuner unit is situated inside the PC cabinet, and hence, is prone to interference from various PC components, which effects quality.

When a tuner is at work, it heavily loads the PCI bus. Also, some motherboards might not have a spare PCI slot to accommodate the PCI TV tuner card, and those with laptops just cannot use one.



Mercury TV
Tuner Card

In such situations, using an external TV tuner is a good solution. Remember, external TV tuners are sub-divided into two categories: USB and set-top tuners—which use a loopback cable from the VGA-out of the display card to the unit and from the unit to the CRT. The Digit Test Centre received three TV tuners in each of these categories.

External USB TV Tuners

TV tuners of this type connect to the USB port of the PC. Due to the high data rate required for the transfer of information from the TV tuner to the PC, all the tuners of these type work on the USB 2.0 interface, which ideally supports a data throughput of 480 Mbps. AVerMedia, Tech-Com and Pinnacle sent us TV tuners of this type.

Features

All the tuners in this category had the necessary input/output ports. The Pinnacle PCTV MediaCenter came with just a single USB cable, whereas the others came with a few more cables.

The AVerMedia AVerTV USB 2.0 did not come with a remote, which is a must for any TV tuner. The

Scoreboard - TV Tuner

Internal PCI TV Tuners

BEST BUY digit MAY 2005 BEST BUY digit MAY 2005								
BRAND	AVerMedia	Compro	Compro	Compro	Mercury	MSI	MSI	Pinnacle
Model	AVerTV GO 007	VideoMate PVR/FM	VideoMate Gold II	VideoMate Gold Plus II	TV Tuner Card	Mega TV Tuner Card	TV@nywhere Master	PCTV Rave
Features	26.24	26.08	24.33	28.01	23.02	18.03	27.39	16.63
Type(Internal/External)	Internal PCI	Internal PCI	Internal PCI	Internal PCI	Internal PCI	Internal PCI	Internal PCI	Internal PCI
Tuner Type (TV/FM)	TV/FM	TV/FM	TV	TV/FM	TV/FM	TV	TV/FM	TV
TV Chip	Philips SAA7130HL	Philips SAA7130HL	Philips SAA7134HL	Philips SAA7134HL	Philips SAA7130HL	Conexant CX23881-19	Conexant CX23881-19	Philips SAA7134HL
Stereo or Mono TV Sound	Mono	Mono	Stereo	Stereo	Mono	Stereo	Stereo	Stereo
I/O ports	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Audio In/Out	Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In
Remote Control (Y/N)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗	✓	✗
No. of Buttons on Remote	34	32	32	32	24	NA	24	NA
Connecting cables provided	Stereo cable, FM aerial	Stereo cable, FM aerial	Stereo cable, FM aerial	Stereo cable, FM aerial	Stereo cable	Stereo cable, S-video to S-video	Stereo cable, S-video to S-video, FM aerial	Stereo cable
Software	Drivers, PVR Software	Drivers, PVR Software	Drivers, PVR Software, Ulead MovieStudio 2 SE	PVR Software, Ulead MovieFactory 2 SE & VideoStudio 7 SE DVD	Drivers, PVR Software	Drivers, PVR Software, InterVideo WinCinema suite	Drivers, PVR Software, InterVideo WinDVD Creator Plus	Drivers, PVR Software
PVR/Timeshift	✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓	✓/✓
MPEG1/MPEG2/MPEG4	✓/✓/✓	✓/✓/✗	✓/✓/✗	✓/✓/✗	✓/✗/✗	✓/✓/✗	✓/✓/✗	✓/✓/✗
Ease of installation (Scale of 5)	3	4	4	4	2.5	3.5	3.5	3
Performance	29.04	32.42	31.50	31.50	27.38	26.27	25.79	19.64
No. of TV channels detected (Out of 87)	86	84	87	87	85	75	77	27
Visual quality (Scale of 5)	3.5	4.25	3.75	3.75	3.25	3	3	3.25
Video capture Test (Frames dropped)	4	0	0	0	6	3	5	2
Price Index	13.72	20.29	13.72	11.73	27.00	13.72	13.72	13.54
Price (Rs)	2950	1995	2950	3450	1499	2950	2950	2990
Overall Score (Out of 100)	69.00	78.79	69.55	71.24	77.40	58.01	66.90	49.81